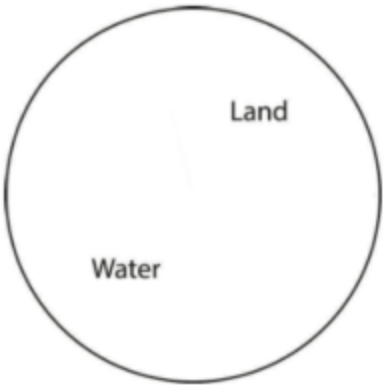
6 Major Geographical Forms

Topics covered

- Continents
- Oceans and seas
- Mountains, hills and valleys
- Rivers
- Plateaus and plains
- Deserts
- Some other landforms

You learnt earlier that nearly three parts of the earth are water. This diagram represents the earth. Colour the water blue and the land green. Then fill in the blanks:

1. The surface of the earth which is nearly three parts is ..... .
2. About one part of the earth's surface is..... .



The areas of land and water on earth are shaped into different forms, which you will now read about.

CONTINENTS

Though land covers only one part of the earth's surface, it is spread across the whole earth. The largest areas of land are called continents. There are seven continents. These are:

- Asia
- Europe
- South America
- Antarctica
- Africa
- North America
- Australia

India is in the southern part of the continent of Asia.

Did you Know?

Almost all the water on earth is salty. Most of this is in the seas and oceans, but some is found in lakes.

Map of the world

OCEANS AND SEAS

Some continents are separated by large areas of water. The very large and deep areas of water are called oceans. The five oceans are:

- Pacific Ocean
- Atlantic Ocean
- Indian Ocean
- Arctic Ocean
- Southern Ocean

Did you Know?

Many thousands of years ago, there was only one big piece of land on the surface of the earth. Over a very long period of time, this slowly broke up into different parts. These moved apart to form the seven continents.

The smaller areas of water are called seas. Some important seas are:

- Mediterranean Sea
- Black Sea
- Arabian Sea
- South China Sea

Find these seas in a map in your atlas.

The wind pushes the water in the oceans and seas, making it move. This movement makes **waves** in the water, which look like a line of moving water. During a storm, when the wind blows strongly, the waves can be high and powerful. This is dangerous for boats and for people who may be in the water.

Waves in the sea

The areas where the land meets the sea are called **coasts**. Where the coast is flat, it is called a beach.

Many beaches have sand. People go to sandy beaches to enjoy the sea.

MOUNTAINS, HILLS AND VALLEYS

The highest portions of land are called mountains. They are formed due to the movements inside the earth that sometimes change the surface of the earth. The tip of a mountain is called a peak. Often mountains are joined together in a chain. This is called a mountain range. The Himalayas are the world's highest mountain range. They are spread over the northern part of India, and across other countries.

Mountains in the Himalayan mountain range

High areas of land which are not as tall as mountains are known as hills. A chain of hills is called a range of hills. The low land lying

between two hills or two mountains is called a valley. Often streams or rivers flow through valleys. Such a valley is called a river valley.

The very highest part of mountains, that are always snow-covered, have no life, but plants, animals and people can live on the hills and in the valleys.

The river Tista flowing through a valley in the Himalayas

RIVERS

A large body of water that flows continuously from a high land to lower land is called a river. Small rivers that have less water are called streams. Rivers and streams contain a large part of the water found on land. The place where a river begins its journey is called its **source**. Rivers usually flow into a sea or an ocean. The place where a river ends its journey is called its mouth.

Discuss

Have you seen any of these landforms? Share your experience in class.

PLATEAUS AND PLAINS

A large stretch of high land that is flat on top is called a plateau. It is also often called a 'tableland' because it is high and flat like a table.

A stretch of low, flat land or almost flat land is called a plain. Plains are formed when rivers bring down mud and soil from the mountains. Whenever there is a flood in a river, the soil that it carries is spread out on the land. Over many, many hundreds of years this forms a plain. There is a large plain in north India called, the Great Northern Plain.

Part of the plain of north India with hills in the background

Low flat land along the coast is called a coastal plain. Coastal plains are generally sandy. India has two long stretches of plains along the east and west coasts. The soil on the plains is very good for plants. People can grow crops and live in such places.

DESERTS

A desert is dry land which receives little or no rainfall year after year. There are two main kinds of deserts, hot deserts and cold deserts.

Hot deserts are sandy, windy, hot and very dry. The largest desert, the Sahara in North Africa, is a hot and sandy desert. The strong winds in sandy deserts blow the sand into huge sand hills, called sand dunes. Some deserts like the Gobi Desert in Asia, are rocky.

Large areas of land that always remain frozen are called cold deserts. Antarctica is a cold desert. It is the coldest and driest continent on earth.

Nothing grows in the cold deserts. In the hot deserts there are only a few plants and animals that are able to survive.

Sand dunes change their shape every time the wind blows.

SOME OTHER LANDFORMS

Island

An island is a piece of land that is *surrounded by water on all sides*. Australia is an island continent. Often, islands in the sea are the tops of very tall underwater mountains. A group of islands found close together is called an **archipelago** (pronounced arki-pe-lego). The Lakshadweep Islands in the Arabian Sea is an archipelago.

Lake

A lake is a large body of water *surrounded on all sides by land*. The continent of North America has many large lakes. The Caspian Sea in Asia is the world's largest lake. It is so large that it is called a sea. Smaller water bodies surrounded by land are called ponds.

Isthmus

An isthmus is a narrow strip of land which *joins two larger parts of land*. The continents of North America and South America are joined by an isthmus called the Isthmus of Panama.

Strait

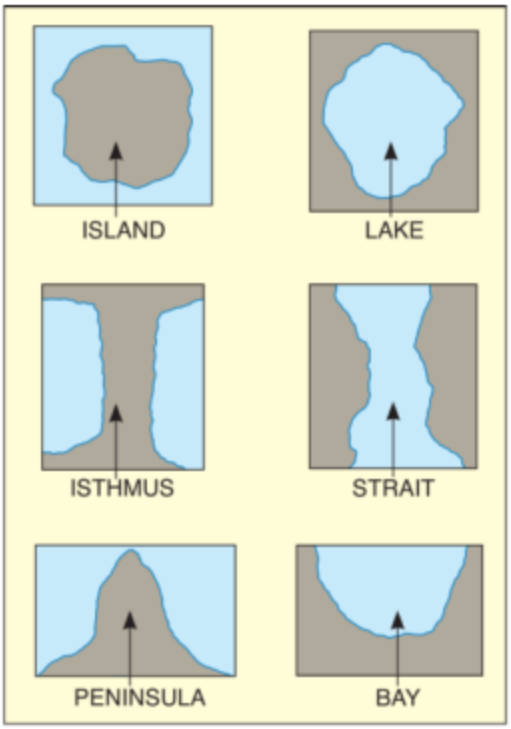
Sometimes a narrow stretch of the sea flows between two large land areas. This stretch of water *joining two large expanses of sea* is called a strait. The Palk Strait lies between India and the island of Sri Lanka. It joins the waters of the Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea.

Peninsula

A peninsula is a piece of land that is surrounded by the sea on three sides but joined to a larger piece of land on the fourth side. The southern half of India has the sea on three sides. This part of India is a peninsula.

Bay

When a part of the sea fills up a wide curve in the land, we call this a bay. The Bay of Bengal is an example of a bay.



Some other landforms

Think and answer

What is the difference between:

- An island and a lake?
- A strait and an isthmus?

Values and Life Skills

What are some ways in which these landforms are useful for people?

REMEMBER

1. The earth is nearly three parts water and about one part land.
2. The land is spread out across the earth.
3. The land and water bodies are shaped into different geographical forms, also called landforms.
4. The geographical forms or landforms are: continents, oceans, seas, mountains, hills, valleys, plateaus, plains, deserts and several others.
5. Rivers are formed when water flows continuously from high land to lower land.

NEW WORDS

Wave	a raised line of water that moves across the surface of the sea, ocean etc.
Coast	the land beside or near the sea or ocean
Archipelago	a group of islands and the sea surrounding them

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

1. The largest areas of land are called ..... and the largest areas of water are called ..... .
2. The highest parts of land are called ..... and parts of land that are less high are called ..... .
3. A ..... is a large area of water surrounded by land on all sides, but an ..... is a piece of land surrounded by water on all sides.
4. A ..... is a stretch of water that joins two larger water bodies but an ..... is a piece of land that joins two land areas.
5. When the sea fills up a wide curve in the land, it is called a ..... .

B. Write true or false.

Correct the false sentences in your notebook.

1. Lowland between hills or mountains is called a plateau.
2. In some places rivers flow from lowland to highland.
3. A river valley is the name of a river.
4. A tableland is useful for making tables.
5. A plain is formed over many hundreds of years.

C. Match the following.

A	B
1. Highest mountains	a. a few plants and animals are able to live here
2. Hills and valleys	b. nothing can grow here
3. Cold deserts	c. soil is very good for plants here
4. Hot deserts	d. plants, animals and people can live here
5. Plains	e. no life at all here

D. Choose the correct answer.

Choose the right word from this box to write in the blanks below.

dunes	archipelago	peninsula	wave	peak	seas
source	mouth	coast			

1. Hills of sand: .....
2. Group of islands in the sea: .....
3. Land that is surrounded on three sides by the sea: .....
4. Where land meets the sea: .....
5. Mountain tip: .....
6. Smaller areas of water than oceans: .....
7. The beginning of a river: .....
8. The end of the river's journey: .....
9. Raised line of water moving across an ocean: .....

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What is a mountain range? Give an example.
2. Write two or three sentences to explain how rivers are formed.
3. What is a plain?
4. How is a plain formed?
5. What is a desert?
6. What is the difference between hot and cold deserts? Give an example of each.

THINGS TO DO

TP A. Picture study

1. On a blank world map like the one given, label the seven continents and five oceans.
2. Write the direction of these places in the blanks using only N (North), S (South), E (East) or W (West). Use the directions cross in the map to help you.

a. Antarctica: ..... of the equator

b. Arctic Ocean: ..... of the equator

c. Indian Ocean: ..... of India

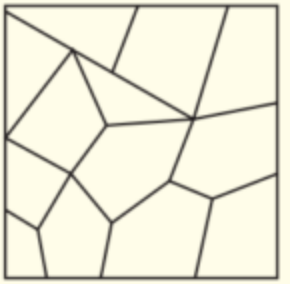
d. Atlantic Ocean: ..... of Africa and ..... of South America

e. Pacific Ocean: ..... of Asia

f. Africa: ..... of Europe

g. Australia: ..... of the equator

SI B. On your own



Make a puzzle of the world.

You will need: An outline map of the world, colours, mount board, gum, scissors

What to do:

1. Colour and label the map.
2. Paste it neatly on a piece of mount board.
3. Turn this board over and mark out the shapes of your puzzle pieces. Ask a grown-up to help you cut these out. You have a puzzle that you and your friends can play with.

C. In a group

Have a landforms exhibition!

Divide your class into groups. Each group should choose a landform and make a model of it on a tray. Use clay, cotton, blue washing powder, crepe paper, twigs, toy animals, etc. for your model.

WEBLINK

Ocean waves, sandy beach: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=E7qRkUYu580 (accessed on 27 July 2017)